Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Elizabeth Barrett Browning's "The Poet"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of Elizabeth Barrett Browning's notion that poets have been set in our midst for a specific purpose include

alliteration,
anthropomorphism,
apostrophe,
archaism,
chiasmus,
controlling image,
enclosed rhyme,
iambic pentameter,
imagery,
internal rhyme,
inversion,
meter,
metonymy,
octave,
polyptoton,
rhyme scheme,
sestet,
simile,
sonnet,
speaker,
syzygy,
theme,
tone, and
volta.

The contestant might recognize that Browning's foundational comparisons—godlike and childlike, a pairing of similes following the volta "Why" (read as "then") offer a focus for the speaker's argument that poets exist among us for a specific purpose, that purpose being to alert us to the beauty of the everyday world. (making the familiar unfamiliar)

The sonnet's argument that the poet is childlike in her recognition of beauty, that she sees everything as if seeing it for the first time (lines 1-3) and is thus godlike in recognizing the beauty: God, the argument infers, "would tire" of what is oftenest viewed (line 2) were he like ordinary men "too early dispossessed" (line 8) of wonderment.

The young critic should find in the sonnet's last two lines (as is with many sonnets) a summing up of the sonnet's argument, which points to the poet's specific purpose. The poets in our midst are to write memorable poetry—the ceaseless-tunes—that draw attention—praise—to the world's beauty.